

Shenhui, Huineng, and the Sixth Patriarch

1. The succession problem

If Hongren is the fifth patriarch, who is sixth? Later tradition answers Huineng. Eighth-century evidence shows that this answer was not simply inherited without dispute. Shenhui publicly attacked the lineage of Shenxiu's descendants and promoted Huineng as the sole legitimate heir. The familiar genealogy is therefore also the outcome of a contest over succession.

2. Shenhui's polemic

Shenhui's rhetoric joins two moves: doctrinal contrast and genealogical exclusion. He links his opponents with gradualism and positions Huineng's line as sudden. The force comes from making doctrinal correctness and legitimate succession reinforce each other. But this creates a methodological trap: if later sources adopt Shenhui's categories, we can mistakenly use the result of the polemic as independent evidence that the polemic was accurate.

3. Huineng before the Platform Sutra

Historical information about Huineng is thin relative to his later stature. The dramatic biography - southern layman, rice-pounding laborer, secret transmission, flight from the monastery - is best approached as hagiography that encodes values: awakening unconstrained by elite learning, authority not reducible to rank, and the inversion of expected status. A hagiographic story can be doctrinally dense even where its documentary value is limited.

4. The Platform Sutra as a layered text

The Platform Sutra is unusual in casting a Chinese master's teaching in the prestigious form of a 'sutra.' Dunhuang manuscripts help reveal an early textual history, while later editions revise and expand the work. Treat 'the Platform Sutra says' with caution. Which recension? Which stratum? Which editorial setting? Textual plurality is not a nuisance around the real teaching; it is part of how the teaching became real to later readers.

5. Sudden and gradual

A crude model says: Northern = gradual, Southern = sudden. A better analysis separates at least three questions. Is awakening temporally sudden? Is cultivation before awakening necessary? Is cultivation after awakening necessary? Can language or ritual prepare conditions without causing awakening? Different teachers can answer these differently while all using the word 'sudden.'

6. A reconstruction

Shenhui's strongest argument can be represented as: (1) awakening cannot be composed incrementally out of deluded states; (2) therefore the decisive seeing must be non-gradual; (3) a lineage that treats purification as the production of enlightenment mistakes means for realization; (4) Huineng's line preserves the correct relation between practice and realization. Objection: premise (1) does not show that long preparation or later cultivation is irrelevant.

7. Genealogy and truth

Suppose Shenhui helped create the historical dominance of Huineng's lineage. It does not follow that every doctrine attributed to Huineng is false. Conversely, the spiritual value of a doctrine does not prove the biography attached to it. The intellectually difficult position is to let textual criticism and philosophical evaluation proceed independently, then ask how their results interact.

8. What to retain

By the end of this unit, 'patriarch' should no longer look like a simple biographical label. It is a technology of memory that connects awakening, textual identity, ritual transmission, and institutional authorization. Later Zen will repeatedly deny mediation while building extremely sophisticated forms of mediation. That tension is a recurring subject, not an embarrassment to be explained away.

1. Three claims that must be separated

- 1 Succession claim: Huineng was Hongren's uniquely authorized heir.
- 2 Doctrinal claim: Huineng represented sudden awakening while rival teachers represented gradual cultivation.
- 3 Canonical claim: the received Platform Sutra reliably preserves Huineng's teaching.

The three claims support one another inside later tradition, but they require different historical arguments. Evidence for the prominence of Huineng in a later lineage does not by itself date a passage in the Platform Sutra; a passage in that text does not by itself establish a private succession scene.

2. Shenhui's argument

A simplified reconstruction of Shenhui's polemical strategy is: (1) Chan authority ought to descend through one legitimate patriarchal line. (2) Hongren's legitimate line passed through Huineng, not the teachers then prominent at court. (3) Huineng's teaching is properly characterized as sudden, while the rival line is gradual. Therefore (4) the lineage represented by Huineng is both genealogically and doctrinally superior. Each premise is contestable. The importance of the argument lies partly in how successfully later Chan came to remember the field through its categories.

Defending premise (1)?

The single-line model looks natural only after the tradition has normalized it. Early Buddhist authority could be organized through ordination, textual mastery, visionary sanction, monastic office, patronage, or multiple teacher relationships. A unique patriarchal line is one possible architecture among others. Once adopted, however, it creates a powerful zero-sum structure: if the robe, title, or mind seal belongs to one heir, rival claims are not merely different pedagogies but illegitimate succession.

The poem contest as a case

The famous verse contest between Shenxiu and Huineng is ideal material for separating literary force from event history. The paired verses make gradual polishing and sudden non-abiding visually memorable. That makes the story extraordinarily effective pedagogy and polemic. Its effectiveness is not evidence that the scene occurred exactly as narrated. Read it first as a constructed contrast: what conception of practice does each verse represent, what does the story need the reader to conclude, and why is anonymous kitchen labor an effective setting for the victorious outsider?

Platform Sutra strata

The Dunhuang version and later recensions show that the Platform Sutra has a textual history. Yampolsky's translation and John Jorgensen's historical work make it difficult to treat the work as a stenographic record of one sermon. Yet textual layering does not make the work less important. On the contrary, it lets us see successive communities defining Huineng, ordination, no-thought, repentance, precepts, and lineage through a text that itself became a ritual and institutional object.

Two horns

Either the sudden/gradual contrast reports a stable doctrinal division that already organized the relevant communities, or the contrast was sharpened retrospectively by controversy. If the first, we need early evidence that rivals accepted roughly those descriptions of themselves. If the second, the categories may still track real differences, but they cannot simply be read back as neutral self-identifications. A defensible history can allow both: polemic may exaggerate a distinction without inventing every difference from nothing.

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